the individual acquired such monstrous size chiefly because Stalin himself, using all conceivable methods, supported the glorification of his own person.' In the speech, Khrushchev repeated Lenin's warning that Stalin was likely to abuse his power, and cited countless instances of excesses, including purges, a cult of personality, foreign policy errors, secret plots to kill critics, and military blunders which cost countless lives.

When informed about the speech, Honecker could scarcely believe his ears. In a 1990 interview, he admitted to tearing down a picture of the late dictator from his bedroom wall. 'This was so to speak, my first emotional reaction. It was all very shameful for us, those of us who had honoured Stalin so much.'2

As details of the speech passed from lip to lip, Ulbricht was asked what he should say to East Germans studying at the party school in Moscow: 'You can tell them Stalin is no longer considered a classic,' he snorted.

But joking aside, Ulbricht was soon under pressure to join in the anti-Stalin onslaught. Loathe to push his hero into the shadows, he made halfhearted criticism of the former dictator, accusing him of 'self-adulation and disfigurement of the history of the party' in his post-war writings. Beyond that, he resisted all efforts toward supporting Khrushchev's de-Stalinisation which – over time – heralded in economic reforms and on the cultural front, opened new contacts with the outside world.3

As Stalin was consigned to a no-man's land of history, a new wind blew across the Soviet Union, as thousands of former dissidents were released from jails, and once banned foreign books, movies and music became available. Soviet agriculture, which Stalin had virtually destroyed, was resuscitated, and a new surge in housing construction allowed hundreds of thousands to move out of jammed collective apartments.

But those expecting the winds of change to whistle through the streets of Berlin were left sorely disappointed. The Soviet ambassador, Georgi Pushkin, along with Karl Schirdewan – now considered one of the brightest lights in the SED, and viewed by Khrushchev as a potential successor to Ulbricht – expressed displeasure at the lack of reforms.4